

# 12-Week Sprint Triathlon Training Plan

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## Beginner to Sprint Ready

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**Race Distance:** 750m Swim | 20km Bike | 5km Run

**Target Audience:** Beginners able to swim 15 min, bike 30 min, run 30 min

**Weekly Training:** 5-6 days per week | 4-6 hours total

**Program Structure:** 3 x 4-week cycles (Test → Build → Recover)

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## Program Overview

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This 12-week plan uses proven periodization principles to progressively build your fitness across all three disciplines. Each 4-week cycle includes a testing phase to establish baseline fitness, a build phase to increase volume and intensity, and a recovery week to allow adaptation.

### Key Principles:

- Progressive overload: Gradual increases in volume and intensity
  - Specificity: Training mimics race demands
  - Recovery: Built-in rest days and recovery weeks
  - Flexibility: Adjust rest days to fit your schedule
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## CYCLE 1: BASE BUILDING (Weeks 1-4)

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### Week 1: Test Week

**Monday:** Rest day - Meal prep and schedule planning

**Tuesday:** Swim Test (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5-10 min easy swim
- Main Set: Swim 15 min max distance (take breaks as needed)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim
- *Note: Record distance for baseline*

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace
- Use easy gear with high cadence (90+ RPM)
- Focus on smooth pedaling, not speed

**Thursday:** Run Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk
- *Note: Record distance for baseline*

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

- Swim easy, take breaks as needed
- Focus on form and breathing

**Saturday:** Bike Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy
- Main Set: Bike 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy
- *Note: Record distance for baseline*

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

- Run/walk easy (conversational pace)
- Take breaks as needed

**Weekly Volume:** ~4 hours

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## Week 2: Build Week

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Build (25 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 4 x 3 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace
- High cadence focus

**Thursday:** Run Build (40 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 4 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

- Swim easy, focus on technique

**Saturday:** Bike Build (60 min)

- Warm-up: 12 min easy
- Main Set: 4 x 8 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 10 min easy

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

- Run/walk easy (conversational pace)

**Weekly Volume:** ~4.5 hours

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## Week 3: Build Week

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Build (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 4 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace

**Thursday:** Run Build (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 5 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

- Swim easy

**Saturday:** Bike + Run Brick (65 min)

- Bike: 12 min warm-up easy, 4 x 9 min at test pace (2 min easy between), 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 5 min easy into race pace effort
- *This teaches your legs to run after biking*

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

- Run/walk easy

**Weekly Volume:** ~4.5 hours

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**Week 4: Recovery Week**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

- Swim easy, focus on form

**Wednesday:** Rest day

**Thursday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace

**Friday:** Rest day

**Saturday:** Easy Run (30 min)

- Run/walk easy

**Sunday:** Rest day

**Weekly Volume:** ~2 hours

*Recovery weeks allow your body to adapt and prevent overtraining*

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## CYCLE 2: INTENSITY BUILDING (Weeks 5-8)

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### Week 5: Test Week (Retest)

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Test (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5-10 min easy swim
- Main Set: Swim 15 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim
- *Compare to Week 1 - you should see improvement*

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

**Thursday:** Run Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

**Saturday:** Bike Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy
- Main Set: Bike 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

**Weekly Volume:** ~4 hours

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## **Week 6: Build Week with Intensity**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Intervals (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 4 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

**Thursday:** Run Intervals (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 5 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

**Saturday:** Bike Intervals (60 min)

- Warm-up: 12 min easy
- Main Set: 4 x 9 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 10 min easy

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

**Weekly Volume:** ~4.5 hours

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## **Week 7: Build Week with Longer Efforts**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Build (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 4 x 5 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

**Thursday:** Run Build (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 6 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

**Saturday:** Bike + Run Brick (70 min)

- Bike: 12 min warm-up, 4 x 10 min at test pace (2 min easy between), 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 8 min easy into race pace
- *Longer brick workout to build race-specific fitness*

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

**Weekly Volume:** ~5 hours

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## **Week 8: Recovery Week**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

**Wednesday:** Rest day

**Thursday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

**Friday:** Rest day

**Saturday:** Easy Run (30 min)

**Sunday:** Rest day

**Weekly Volume:** ~2 hours

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## **CYCLE 3: RACE PREPARATION (Weeks 9-12)**

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### **Week 9: Test Week (Final Assessment)**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Test (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5-10 min easy swim
- Main Set: Swim 15 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim
- *Final baseline - should show significant improvement*

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

**Thursday:** Run Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

**Saturday:** Bike Test (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy
- Main Set: Bike 30 min max distance
- Cool-down: 5 min easy

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

**Weekly Volume:** ~4 hours

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## **Week 10: Race Simulation**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Intervals (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 3 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

**Thursday:** Run Intervals (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 6 x 4 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

**Saturday:** Full Triathlon Simulation (90 min)

- Swim: 15 min easy (simulating 750m)
- Transition: 3-5 min
- Bike: 30 min easy (simulating 20km)
- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 10 min easy (simulating 5km)
- *This is your dress rehearsal - practice transitions, nutrition, pacing*

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

**Weekly Volume:** ~5 hours

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## **Week 11: Peak Week**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Swim Intervals (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

**Wednesday:** Easy Bike (45 min)

**Thursday:** Run Intervals (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 6 x 5 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

**Friday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

**Saturday:** Bike + Run Brick (75 min)

- Bike: 12 min warm-up, 5 x 10 min at test pace (2 min easy between), 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 2-3 min
- Run: 10 min easy into race pace
- *Final hard effort before taper*

**Sunday:** Easy Run (30 min)

**Weekly Volume:** ~5 hours

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## **Week 12: Race Week & Taper**

**Monday:** Rest day

**Tuesday:** Easy Swim (20 min)

- Swim easy, focus on relaxation

**Wednesday:** Rest day

**Thursday:** Easy Bike (30 min)

- Very easy pace, just moving

**Friday:** Easy Swim (15 min)

- Short, easy, confidence-building

**Saturday:** Rest day - Final preparations

**Sunday:** RACE DAY!

- Arrive early
- Warm up gently
- Review your race plan
- Trust your training
- Have fun!

**Weekly Volume:** ~1.5 hours

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## Training Terminology

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**Test Pace (TP):** The pace you established during your test weeks. Maintain this effort level during interval workouts.

**Easy/Conversational Pace:** You should be able to hold a conversation. If you can't speak, you're going too fast.

**Warm-up (WU):** Gradually increase heart rate and blood flow. Never start hard.

**Main Set (MS):** The primary focus of the workout.

**Cool-down (CD):** Gradually decrease intensity to aid recovery.

**Recovery Interval (RI):** Easy effort between hard efforts to allow partial recovery.

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## Nutrition During Training

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### **Pre-Workout (30-60 min before):**

- Banana with almond butter
- Toast with jam
- Rice cakes with honey
- *Something light and easily digestible*

### **During Workout (sessions >90 min):**

- Water with electrolytes
- Energy gels or sports drink
- *Not needed for most sessions in this plan*

### **Post-Workout (within 30 min):**

- Protein + carbs (chicken with rice, protein smoothie, turkey sandwich)
  - Rehydrate with electrolytes
  - *Critical for recovery*
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## Recovery & Injury Prevention

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**Sleep:** Aim for 7-9 hours per night. This is when adaptation happens.

**Stretching:** 10-15 min after each workout, especially legs and shoulders.

**Foam Rolling:** 5-10 min on rest days for muscle recovery.

**Cross-Training:** Optional easy yoga or swimming on rest days.

**Listen to Your Body:** If something hurts (not just tired), take an extra rest day.

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## Race Week Tips

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- Reduce training volume by 50-70%
  - Maintain intensity but reduce duration
  - Practice your race-day routine
  - Lay out all gear the night before
  - Get good sleep the 2-3 nights before
  - Eat familiar foods
  - Arrive at race venue early for parking and setup
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## Post-Race

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Congratulations on completing your first sprint triathlon! Now:

- Rest for 3-5 days with easy movement only
  - Reflect on what went well and what to improve
  - Consider your next goal (another sprint, Olympic distance, or half ironman)
  - Celebrate your achievement!
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**Remember:** This is YOUR training plan. Adjust rest days as needed to fit your life. Consistency beats perfection. Trust the process!